> “THE STRENGTH OF THE PACK IS THE WOLF, THE STRENGTH OF THE WOLF IS THE PACK.”
>
> **MOTTO**, 3RD LIGHT ARMORED RECONNAISSANCE BATTALION

exposure to combat. Yet they had taken punishment from the enemy without cracking and had gone on doing the job they were employed to do. Morale in the Marines, as in the rest of US ground forces in Vietnam, was nonetheless seriously on the wane. As the number of Marines making their final journey home in a green rubber bodybag mounted, the ordinary grunt’s focus inevitably fixed on surviving his 13-month tour of duty. Even without the persistent criticism of the war being expressed by journalists and the anti-war movement in the United States, men could see that the prospect of anything that could be called “victory” was remote. Maintaining commitment was especially hard for black Marines. After the assassination of civil rights leader Martin Luther King in April 1968, many African-Americans felt torn in their allegiance, unsure whether they were right to be fighting for the United States at all.

**Urban combat**
The Tet Offensive saw the city of Hue overrun by NVA troops. Under the constant threat of snipers, the Marines of Task Force X-Ray fought street-by-street for a month to regain the city.

## AFTER VIETNAM

It was with relief that the Marines withdrew from Vietnam in 1971, leaving the war to be fought by the army alone. By then, they had long ceased to carry out offensive operations. Around 800,000 Marines had served in the war. Of these, 13,091 had been killed and 51,392 wounded in action. Overall, Marines accounted for about a quarter of all US combat deaths in Vietnam. Rebuilding the image and morale of the Corps was a task that took a decade, but the Marines have survived to play a prominent role in subsequent conflicts, including the invasion and occupation of Afghanistan and Iraq in the 21st century.



**Purple Heart**
The Purple Heart, or Badge of Military Merit, was instituted by George Washington (depicted) in 1782, when he was commander-in-chief of the Continental Army. It is awarded to soldiers either wounded or killed in battle.